

A FREE DM TABLE · LONG ISLAND DUNGEON MASTER

THE SUN GETS A TURN

A d100 for what the desert does on its own initiative.

d100 + d20 · ten bands · one printable card · system-agnostic (SRD 5.1)

A d100 for what the desert does on its own initiative, and a d20 for why today is worse than usual.

Use it: any fight, chase or crossing in dry country. Roll the d20 once when the party sets out. Roll the d100 on initiative count 20, once a round. No stat blocks, nothing to convert, and every row runs on rules your table already knows.



THE PROBLEM

Your players are four days into a hundred miles of dry country and the only thing that has happened to them is a giant scorpion.

That is not a monster problem. The scorpion was fine. The problem is that for four days the most dangerous thing in the scene has been sitting there doing nothing, and the way you have been running it, the desert is a beige room with an encounter table bolted to the wall.

Then the boss fight starts, and it is a beige room with a boss in it.

The fix is not more encounters. You do not need another creature. You need the land to take a turn, the same way anything else in the fight takes a turn, and you need it to cost something other than hit points.

I have been running games for 30+ years and I ran deserts badly for most of them. What changed it was not better description. It was giving the place an initiative count.



THE THREE RULES

1. GIVE IT INITIATIVE 20

The desert acts on initiative count 20, losing ties. That is the slot the rules already hand to a lair, so your table understands it before you explain it. On the desert's turn, roll the d100 below or pick the row you want.

One row a round is right. Two is a set piece, and a set piece should be something you decided on before the session, not something the dice did to you.

Outside combat it is the same idea on a slower clock: roll once per hour of hard travel, or once per leg of the journey if you are covering ground fast.

It hits everybody. The desert does not take sides, and a table notices fast if it only ever lands on the players. There is one exception and it is worth more than a rule: things born out here have already solved the grit and the sun angle, so rows 22 and 42 skip them. Your party squints. The thing they are fighting does not.

2. ALMOST NONE OF IT IS DAMAGE, ON PURPOSE

Read down the table. Three rows out of a hundred deal a point or two. Everything else takes footing, sight, sound, water, or a turn.

A desert that deals 4 damage a round is a bad monster with no stat block, and your players will treat it the way they treat weather in a video game. A desert that has the archer squinting into the sun, the wizard's focus thirty feet downwind, and the only shade on the map sliding away from the wounded is the fight.

3. TELL THEM IT IS COMING

The dust wall is visible for a full minute before it arrives. The shade is obviously going to move, because the sun is obviously moving. Say so.

Announced pressure makes players plan. Unannounced pressure makes them fatalistic, and a fatalistic table stops trying things, which is the exact thing you were trying to fix.



ABOUT THE HEAT CLOCK

Seven rows below say the heat “ticks.” Use whatever your table already uses for that.

If you use nothing, use this: mark a box for every hour a character spends in the open with the sun up. On the fourth box, one level of exhaustion. The boxes clear on a long rest taken in shade with water to spare.

The rulebook has its own numbers for thirst and they are stricter than mine. Use those if your table wants the survival game played straight. This version exists so the clock is one line you can hold in your head while you are also running a fight.



THE KEY

Ten bands of ten. Find the band, read the row. The first half is the ground and the sky. The second half is everything out here that is alive, or used to be.

THE KEY: READ THIS FIRST

ROLL	THE BAND	WHAT IT COVERS
1-10	The footing	The ground stops being a floor
11-20	The slope	The dunes move and the high ground changes hands
21-30	The wind	What it does to sound, aim and sight
31-40	What the wind takes	Whatever it can lift off you and carry away
41-50	The light	Glare and shadow and distances you cannot judge
51-60	The heat	What it does to metal, to animals and to the clock
61-70	The water	Thirst and mirage and what a skin is worth
71-80	The small lives	The things underfoot and in your clothing
81-90	Something noticed	What follows and circles and waits
91-100	What the desert kept	Ruins and bones and old roads



D100: WHAT THE DESERT DOES ON ITS TURN

THE FOOTING

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 1 **The crust gives.** Whoever is standing on the flattest, most confident piece of ground goes shin-deep into brine and grit. They are prone, and standing up costs their whole movement instead of half.
- 2 **Sand-glass.** A sheet of fused glass under a skin of dust, twenty feet across, and nobody can see where it ends. Difficult terrain. A creature that ends its turn on it makes a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or falls prone.
- 3 **The ground bites.** Anything lying on it starts to cook. A creature that is prone at the start of its turn takes 2 fire damage when it gets up, and so does anyone who put a bare palm down. Dropped metal is too hot to pick up for a minute.
- 4 **A hollow.** The crust over an old cistern gives way. One creature drops five feet into a dry stone pit, prone, with half cover from anything outside it. Climbing out costs ten feet of movement and both hands.
- 5 **Gravel over hardpan.** Loose stone on bare rock, and it rolls. The area is difficult terrain, and any creature that Dashes across it makes a DC 10 Dexterity saving throw or ends the move prone.
- 6 **The salt cuts.** The crust is edged like broken pottery. Moving through it is fine. Going down in it means coming up bleeding from the hands and knees, and out here an open cut is a decision about water.
- 7 **A crack opens.** A fissure four feet wide runs between two people who wanted to be next to each other. It is a jump, or it is a thirty-foot walk around.
- 8 **The ground is warmer than it should be.** Not the sun. Something under it. Nobody has to do anything about this, and your table will not be able to leave it alone.
- 9 **Bones underfoot.** A whole herd went down here and the bones are hollow and dry. Nobody moves quietly through this. Stealth is off the table in this area until somebody thinks of something clever.
- 10 **It holds.** One patch of genuinely good footing, twenty feet across, in the middle of everything else. It is the best place to stand and there is room for two. Point at it and say nothing else.

THE SLOPE

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 11 **The slope runs.** The face of the nearest dune slides. Every creature on it travels 10 feet downhill, and whoever was at the back of the climb is now in front.
- 12 **The face collapses.** The top third of the dune comes down. Anything at the base is buried to the waist and restrained until it, or somebody else, spends an action digging it out.
- 13 **The high ground changes hands.** The ridge everyone was fighting over is a foot lower than it was, and the one nobody wanted is a foot higher. Nothing mechanical happens. The plan changes anyway.
- 14 **A ridge you cannot see over.** A wall of sand rises between two halves of the fight. Neither half knows what the other is doing until somebody climbs, and climbing puts them on a skyline.
- 15 **The wind rebuilds the way you came.** The back-trail is gone. Anyone relying on retracing it needs a new plan, and anyone tracking them has lost the thread too.
- 16 **A slipface.** The far side of this dune is steep enough that going down is one move and coming back up is three. Whoever commits, commits.
- 17 **The crest is knife-thin.** Standing on it means being visible from both sides at once. Nobody holds this and hides.
- 18 **The bowl.** The ground dips. Everyone inside loses sight of the horizon, which means losing sight of whatever was on it. It is cooler down here, and that is a reason to stay too long.
- 19 **The far side is closer than it looked.** Whatever they were pacing themselves to reach is one move away instead of three. Give it to them. The desert is allowed to be generous once an hour.
- 20 **You are being funneled.** The only walkable line runs between two slopes, and it has been the only walkable line for a while now. Somebody should ask who benefits from that.

THE WIND

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 21 The wind takes the words.** Until the end of the next round, nobody hears anything past 30 feet. Spoken spell components still work, because those are said to the spell and not to a friend. Shouted orders do not. The plan they made last round is the plan they have.
- 22 Grit.** Every creature without something across its face has disadvantage on attacks against targets more than 30 feet away, until it spends an action clearing its eyes.
- 23 The dust arrives.** Everything past 30 feet is heavily obscured until the end of the next round. Then it moves on, and they get to see who used the time.
- 24 The air goes dead still.** This is not relief. Until the end of the next round sound carries perfectly: advantage on Perception checks that rely on hearing, for everyone in the scene, including whatever is out past the light. The heat gets a free tick.
- 25 Crosswind.** Ranged attacks past normal range are at disadvantage until the end of the next round, and a thrown weapon that misses lands somewhere useless.
- 26 The wind changes direction.** Everything anybody did to get upwind or downwind of anything is now wrong. Fire, smell and smoke all go the other way.
- 27 A dust devil.** A column of grit walks across the scene on its own schedule. It is not alive and it is not a threat, and the first time it crosses a fight everybody stops for a second.
- 28 It comes in gusts.** The wind arrives in punches with quiet between them. Every other round is a wind round. Let the table work out which is which and use the gap.
- 29 The wind is louder than you are.** Nobody is sneaking up on anybody, and nobody is being sneaked up on either. It cancels out, and everyone is oddly alone in it.
- 30 You can smell what is upwind.** Smoke perhaps. Or an animal. Or rot. Or cooking. Whatever it is, it is closer than they thought, and it is in a direction nobody was watching.

WHAT THE WIND TAKES

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 31 Something light goes.** A hat. An unrolled map. A torch. A focus somebody set down for one second. Pick the thing that will cost the most to lose and put it 30 feet downwind.
- 32 It takes the fire.** Any open flame smaller than a campfire is out. Relighting costs an action and shelter, and there is no shelter.
- 33 It takes the tracks.** Every footprint older than a minute is gone, theirs and everything else's. Whatever they were following, they are now guessing about.
- 34 It fills what you left open.** The pack. The pot. The wound. The waterskin somebody did not stopper. Sand in all of it.
- 35 It takes the smell of you.** And hands it to whatever is downwind, which is a direction nobody has been watching, because the wind was going the other way an hour ago.
- 36 The cloak becomes a sail.** Anyone in a loose garment has disadvantage on Dexterity checks and on Strength checks that involve holding a position, until they stow it or cut it away.
- 37 Sand in the mechanism.** Anything with a moving part sticks. A crossbow. A lock. A lantern's shutter. A clockwork thing. One use, one failure, then it works again once somebody spends a minute on it.
- 38 It takes the throw.** Ropes, grapples and anything else that has to fly true simply do not, once. Try again next round.
- 39 It brings somebody else's rubbish.** A page. A bandage. A broken strap. A child's shoe. It came from upwind, which means people are upwind, which means the map is wrong.
- 40 It takes the light.** A lantern gutters out, or suspended dust eats the edge of a light spell. Bright radius halves until the end of the next round.

THE LIGHT

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 41 **The light goes flat.** No shadows anywhere, so nothing has depth and nothing has a distance. Ranged attacks past half their normal range are at disadvantage until a creature spends an action ranging the shot for everyone.
- 42 **The sun tips over.** The angle drops. Every creature facing into it has disadvantage on ranged attacks until it moves to a different facing. This row costs nothing and almost nobody uses it.
- 43 **Glare off the pan.** The salt throws the whole sky back up at you. Anyone without shaded eyes has disadvantage on sight-based Perception until they get out of the open.
- 44 **Your own shadow is the only cover.** There is nothing else to get behind for two hundred feet in any direction, and everybody works that out at the same moment.
- 45 **Heat shimmer.** Everything past 60 feet is wobbling. Nobody can tell a person from a post, or four riders from six, until they are close.
- 46 **The horizon lies.** The thing they have been walking toward is either much further away or much larger than they assumed. Pick the reading that costs them more, and tell them plainly when they find out.
- 47 **Something flashes, far off.** Metal perhaps. Or glass. Or water. It happens once. It will not happen again while anybody is watching for it.
- 48 **The shade moves.** The one patch of shade in the scene slides 20 feet. Whoever was in it is not now, and getting back into it means crossing open ground while somebody watches them do it.
- 49 **Dark comes fast.** Sunset out here is minutes, not an hour. Whatever they were going to do in daylight, they are doing half of it in the dark.
- 50 **The moon on salt.** Bright enough to read by, which means bright enough to be seen by. Nobody hides tonight, and nobody needs a torch either.

THE HEAT

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 51 Metal turns on you.** Anyone in metal armor, or holding an unwrapped metal weapon, has disadvantage on their next Constitution saving throw, and the heat ticks for them and for nobody else.
- 52 Armor becomes a decision.** Anyone in medium or heavy armor takes their next heat tick an hour early. Taking it off costs ten minutes and leaves them standing in their shirt.
- 53 The water is warm and tastes of the skin.** It still works. Nobody enjoys it, and one person is about to start rationing without telling anybody.
- 54 The sweat stops.** On one character, and it is the dangerous sign. If nobody does anything about it, the heat ticks twice for them at the end of this hour.
- 55 The rock face radiates.** The cliff everybody sensibly put their backs against has been in the sun since dawn. Anyone within five feet of it takes their next heat tick early.
- 56 Wax, glue and pitch fail.** Sealed things unseal. A fletching. A hilt wrap. A stoppered flask. A sealed letter. One of them, and it should be the one that matters.
- 57 The grip slips.** Hands are wet and then dry and then wet again. The next creature to roll a natural 1 on an attack drops the weapon rather than merely missing.
- 58 The animals suffer first.** Any mount or beast is blowing and balking. It obeys one more command, and then it needs water or shade before it obeys another.
- 59 Noon.** For one hour, everything with sense is lying still in shade. Anyone travelling through this takes two heat ticks instead of one, and anyone hunting them is not hunting them right now.
- 60 The heat ticks for everybody.** No save. No exception. No clever answer. The desert is simply hotter than it was an hour ago, and the clock says so.

THE WATER

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 61** **Water, out at the edge of it.** It is not water. Any creature that has gone a day without a full skin makes a DC 10 Wisdom saving throw or spends its next movement walking toward it.
- 62** **A seep.** Real water in a crack in the rock, a cupful an hour. Something already knows about it and comes back to it, and that something has a schedule.
- 63** **A skin fails.** One waterskin has been leaking since morning and nobody noticed. It is the fullest one. Say whose it is, then let them handle the rest of it.
- 64** **Somebody is rationing.** One character has been drinking less than they said. Ask a player quietly whether they want it to be theirs. If nobody bites, make it an NPC, because it should be somebody.
- 65** **Something comes to drink.** A creature you have not introduced yet walks past the fight and goes for the party's waterskins, not the party. If they let it drink, it leaves. If they do not, they learn what it is.
- 66** **The well is salt.** A real well, cut stone, obviously old, obviously dug by people who knew what they were doing. It is undrinkable now, and it was not always.
- 67** **A cache.** Buried water under a marker, and the marker is a code: three stones, a scratch, a knot of cloth. Whoever left it will want to know who took it.
- 68** **Blood is wet.** Somebody at the table is going to think of it. Do not rule it out and do not make it work. It buys an hour and costs the next two.
- 69** **The thirst arrives as a bad decision.** Not as a number. Somebody drinks a whole skin at once, or refuses to drink at all to save it. Give the moment to whoever has been quietest.
- 70** **It rained here, recently.** Green in the low ground, standing water in a hollow, and every living thing for ten miles already knows and is on its way.

THE SMALL LIVES

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 71** **The small things come up.** A 15-foot radius around the loudest creature is difficult terrain until the end of the next round. Anything that ends its turn inside it takes 1 poison damage and spends the next hour finding legs inside its clothing.
- 72** **Something in the boot.** One character, the next time they put a boot on. It is not lethal and it is not funny to them.
- 73** **A snake under the only shade.** The shade is real and the snake is not moving. Somebody has to decide, and the snake does not want the fight either.
- 74** **The flies find the wound.** Anyone below half their hit points is being actively bothered. Concentration, delicate work and sleep all get harder until the wound is properly covered.
- 75** **A swarm crosses the path.** Not hunting. Just going somewhere, in a column six feet wide. Waiting costs ten minutes. Walking through costs 1 poison damage and a great deal of complaining.
- 76** **Ants take the food.** Whatever was not sealed is gone or crawling. One day of rations, and the party gets to decide whose.
- 77** **Something venomous and slow.** It is right there and it is obvious, and it cannot catch anybody. It is only dangerous to someone who is not looking, and eventually somebody will not be looking.
- 78** **Every insect stops at once.** The noise the party had stopped hearing is suddenly not there. Something bigger has arrived and has not shown itself yet.
- 79** **A burrow collapses.** One creature's foot goes through into a tunnel a foot wide and two feet deep. Not a trap, not damage. Whatever dug it is a size worth thinking about.
- 80** **Nothing bites.** No flies. No ants. Nothing underfoot at all, for a hundred feet in every direction. Living things avoid this patch of ground, and they have a reason.

SOMETHING NOTICED

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 81** **Something starts circling.** High up and patient, in no hurry at all. It is not a threat. It is an announcement, and everything on the horizon can read it.
- 82** **A fresh track crosses theirs.** Big and deep, heading the other way at speed. Whatever made it was not hunting. It was leaving.
- 83** **You are being paralleled.** Something has been on the next ridge over for a while, matching pace, never closing. It will keep doing that until they stop.
- 84** **Dust on the horizon that is not weather.** Too narrow and too steady, and pointed at them. In about an hour it resolves into either riders or a herd, and the difference matters.
- 85** **Something answered.** The noise the party made a minute ago got a reply, from a direction nobody expected. It was not words.
- 86** **The scavengers arrive early.** Before anything has died. They know something the party does not, or they know something about the party.
- 87** **A watcher on the ridge.** Visible at the edge of sight, gone the moment anybody looks straight at it. It was there. Do not walk it back.
- 88** **The back-trail has a visitor.** Something has stepped in their prints since they made them, and it did not try to hide that.
- 89** **They are waiting at the water.** Not on the road. Whatever is out here has worked out that everybody has to drink eventually, which is smarter than anything the party has done today.
- 90** **It is herding you.** It is not hunting. Everything that has gone wrong with the footing and the slopes for the last hour has been pushing them in one direction, and it is not the direction they chose.

WHAT THE DESERT KEPT

D100 WHAT HAPPENS

- 91** **Something surfaces.** A wheel. A roof beam. A hand. One creature's movement uncovers a piece of a buried building. It is half cover for anyone who wants it, and it is the first honest evidence that people used to live out here.
- 92** **A road.** Dressed stone under the sand, two carts wide, going somewhere that is not on the map and coming from somewhere that is not either.
- 93** **A cairn.** Stacked stones, put there deliberately and kept that way. Cairns are built by people and rebuilt by people, and this one has been rebuilt.
- 94** **A body, dried whole.** Not a skeleton. Skin and clothes and a face. It could be forty years old or four hundred, and it is still holding something.
- 95** **A wall with a door in it.** Twenty feet of masonry and nothing on either side of it. The door is shut. The door has always been shut.
- 96** **Coin.** A scatter of good metal, worth exactly nothing out here against a full skin. Somebody will pick it up anyway, and that is the whole point of the row.
- 97** **A tree.** A single tree, alive in the middle of nothing. Which means water. Which means it has been fought over.
- 98** **A camp, cold.** Ashes, a windbreak, and the impressions of six people who left in a hurry and left useful things behind.
- 99** **A word cut into stone.** In a hand nobody at the table uses, weathered but deliberate, at about eye height for somebody taller than a person.
- 100** **Nothing.** No wind. No sound. Nothing moving anywhere on the horizon. Skip the desert's turn and run the round as normal. After four rounds of the land doing something, one round of it doing nothing is the loudest row on this table.

D20: WHY TODAY IS WORSE THAN USUAL

Roll once, before they set out. It is the frame the whole day sits in, and it is the one thing on this page the players should be able to work out for themselves by noon.

THE DAY'S CONDITION, ROLLED ONCE

D20 WHAT HAPPENS

- 1 **The wind has been up for three days.** Everyone's eyes are raw before anything begins. Sight-based Perception is at disadvantage until they get an hour out of the wind.
- 2 **The water is short.** Somebody sold them four skins and filled three. They will find out at the worst hour of the worst day, which is the only way anybody ever finds this out.
- 3 **It rained a month ago.** There is green in the low ground. Everything alive out here is therefore also in the low ground, and the low ground is the easy walking.
- 4 **It is the hottest week in nine years.** The last three people they passed said so, and none of them stopped to explain.
- 5 **Something died upwind.** Roll on the 81 to 90 band twice as often today.
- 6 **A caravan is half a day ahead.** Its ruts are the only good footing for miles, and following them means arriving after whatever the caravan already woke.
- 7 **The nights are wrong this month.** Cold enough that a watch stood without a fire costs a level of exhaustion, and a fire out here can be seen from a very long way off.
- 8 **The salt is blowing.** Every cut stings, every skin tastes wrong, and anything steel wants oiling tonight or it starts to pit by morning.
- 9 **There is a wind that arrives at the same hour every afternoon,** and the people who live here plan their whole day around being somewhere else when it does. The party has not met anybody who lives here.
- 10 **The moon is full.** The nights are bright and cold, nobody sleeps well, and everything that hunts at night can see as far as they can.
- 11 **There has been no wind for a week.** The dust the party raises hangs in the air behind them in a line, pointing at exactly where they are.
- 12 **The guide is guessing.** They have not said so and they will not say so. They are one landmark behind and closing the gap by walking everybody faster.
- 13 **Somebody local warned them off this route** this morning, in a tone that was not superstition, and did not explain, and did not stay to argue about it.
- 14 **The animals are wrong.** No birds since dawn. Nothing on the flats. No tracks less than a day old. The whole area has been vacated by things that knew to leave.
- 15 **Two of the skins are the cheap kind,** and the seams are already weeping. They will hold today. They will not hold tomorrow.
- 16 **It is a holy day** for people the party has not met, which out here means the wells are attended and the roads are watched.
- 17 **The heat broke overnight** and it is the most pleasant day in a month. Roll the day's second condition as well, because a mild day is when people take chances.
- 18 **There is smoke on the horizon** in the direction they are going, and it has been there since first light without moving.
- 19 **They are being followed and they already know it.** They simply have not said it to each other yet. Let whoever says it out loud first have the moment.
- 20 **Nothing is wrong.** Good weather. Full skins. Easy footing. Every local they passed on the road this morning was going the other way.

THE CARD

The whole thing, in the shape you keep open next to you.

The three rules

1. The desert acts on initiative 20, losing ties. One row a round.
2. It takes footing, sight, sound, water or a turn. It almost never takes hit points.
3. Announce it before it lands. Announced pressure makes plans; surprise pressure makes shrugs.

The bands

- **1-10 The footing.** The ground stops being a floor.
- **11-20 The slope.** The dunes move and the high ground changes hands.
- **21-30 The wind.** What it does to sound, aim and sight.
- **31-40 What the wind takes.** Whatever it can lift off you and carry away.
- **41-50 The light.** Glare and shadow and distances you cannot judge.
- **51-60 The heat.** What it does to metal, to animals and to the clock.
- **61-70 The water.** Thirst and mirage and what a skin is worth.
- **71-80 The small lives.** The things underfoot and in your clothing.
- **81-90 Something noticed.** What follows and circles and waits.
- **91-100 What the desert kept.** Ruins and bones and old roads.

The heat clock, if you do not have one

One box per hour in the open sun. Four boxes, one level of exhaustion. Clears on a long rest in shade with water to spare.

Roll the d20 once, at the start

It is the day, not the round. The party should be able to work out which row you rolled by about noon.



RUNNING THIS SOMEWHERE OTHER THAN FIFTH EDITION

Almost all of it travels, because almost none of it is a number.

Three rows of the d100 name a saving throw, and it is the same number every time: rows 2, 5 and 61 each ask for a DC 10. Swap in whatever your system calls a test a competent character passes most of the time. Rows 3, 71 and 75 name small damage values, and the smallest meaningful hit in your game will do instead.

The initiative-20 slot is the only structural piece, and it needs a system with an initiative order. In games without one, run the d100 on the same beat you already use for pressure: a clock tick, a failed test, or a scene turn.

The d20 needs nothing at all. It is a fact about the day.



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